

HAYABUSA

Unmanned spacecraft

In September 2005, Hayabusa reached the asteroid Itokawa, about 300 million km (186.4 million miles) away from Earth. It landed on the asteroid's surface and collected dust grains. It was the first mission to bring asteroid samples back to Earth. After analysing the dust grains, scientists found that Itokawa had been part of a larger asteroid that broke up millions of years ago.

DATA FILE



SIZE: 1.5 m (5 ft) wide (without solar panels)



DATE OF LAUNCH: 9 May 2003



MISSION DURATION: 7 years, 1 month, 4 days



SPACE AGENCY: JAXA (Japan)

Solar panels provide power

Hayabusa's cameras confirmed asteroid's Itokawa's elongated shape

Sampler

Hayabusa returned successfully to Earth on 13 June 2010.



Asteroid Itokawa